

The Tempest Essay 2025

1. Intro

- Justice and accountability in the real world is as flimsy as on the magical island where one man controls all fates
- Context
- Thesis
 - Shakespeare's *The Tempest* exposes how power distorts justice and limits moral judgment, while Shakespeare *Behind Bars* reclaims the play as a space for empathy, redemption, and collective healing. Together they reveal that sustaining a just life depends not on authority or power, but on shared understanding and compassion.

2. Prospero takes control of the island, despite Caliban's claim to it.

- he gets to decide what is just and what isn't
- Caliban rebels
- Prospero eventually lets go of control
- The inmates originally craved power, but are now letting go of control and releasing emotion through acting out the play

3. Talk about how power makes violence banal in *The Tempest*:

- Antonio and Sebastian plotting. "Let's take leave of him; / And, by the way, let us murder him" (2.1).
- Inmates tell us how their violent experiences stemmed from normalised violence and lack of guidance

4.